

Chapter 84-1

The word "dream" was frequently mentioned during school days.

From elementary school to high school, every essay Liang Shi wrote about "dreams" was the same: she wanted to take her grandparents to see the ocean.

But it was always mentioned, never fulfilled.

They had actually made a promise—once Liang Shi finished her gaokao¹, they would go see the ocean together.

Liang Shi would plan the itinerary and take the two of them traveling.

Then once Liang Shi started university, they would go on a trip together every year.

But unexpectedly, before Liang Shi could even take her gaokao, her grandfather became seriously ill. Treating his illness exhausted all the family's savings. Back then, her grandfather lay in the hospital bed, and no matter how much anyone tried to persuade him, he wouldn't listen. He insisted on going home, desperately saying the hospital wasn't working and that he was fine.

But at that time, he was actually in so much pain he couldn't sleep at night.

Her grandmother even tacitly agreed with his decision.

Liang Shi knew—they wanted to save the money for her to attend university.

In the end, all the family's money was spent, but her grandfather still couldn't be saved. Her grandmother also collapsed in the kitchen one morning and never woke up again.

Liang Shi couldn't afford tuition for university. It was a regret.

But she didn't feel remorse.

Even though her grandfather couldn't be saved, they had all done their best.

But if she had taken that money to attend university, to her, it would have been like stepping over her grandfather's corpse to see the outside world.

That was too cruel.

Liang Shi stood up and looked toward the sea, gazing at the rising and falling waves. The ocean stretched boundlessly, connecting to the distant horizon.

Liang Shi told Xu Qingzhu that she had never attended university. When she first started acting, she felt particularly inferior, feeling that she didn't deserve her position². So she worked desperately hard—she wanted to be worthy of others' affection.

She had always been moving forward, never stopping.

Liang Shi said, "I never thought I would stand under the spotlight. It all seemed like a dream."

"But you made it." Xu Qingzhu patted her shoulder. "You're destined to be a person who shines brightly, to be liked by many people, to receive a lot of love."

"But later, the dream shattered," Liang Shi said softly.

"Why?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

"Where I come from, girls falling in love with girls isn't really allowed." Liang Shi's memory returned to before she left that place—the overwhelming negative press, the countless insults and humiliations. They dug up all her past, mocking her poor family background, her lack of upbringing, mocking her for not having attended university, mocking her for being a toad wanting to eat swan meat³.

"I've always liked girls, but I knew my profession wouldn't allow me to do so, so I kept my distance from many people." Liang Shi spoke with a slightly bitter smile.

Her light brown pupils gleamed with light, and Xu Qingzhu stood opposite her, right within that halo of light.

"I had already prepared myself to never love anyone for my entire life." Liang Shi sniffled. The sound of the waves seemed to accompany her like background music. The seawater that kept surging in covered her and Xu Qingzhu's ankles. When the tide receded, fine, soft sand clung to both their ankles. "I got used to traveling alone, sleeping alone, eating alone."

Xu Qingzhu's hand reached toward the area beneath her eyes, her fingertips gently stroking over her cold skin.

Liang Shi smiled gently. "I could live my whole life surrounded by liveliness, then return to solitude."

Xu Qingzhu's heart suddenly ached. Her voice also became gentle. "And then? Who shattered your dream?"

Liang Shi pressed her lips together. "I can't really say it was anyone in particular."

"I can only say this was a weakness for me, so when others threw dirty water⁴ on me, I couldn't explain myself." Liang Shi's tears fell directly down, not even passing over her cheeks before landing on the beach, burying themselves in the fine, soft sand, then being swept into the waves. "But Teacher Xu, I really didn't do it."

"Didn't do what?" Xu Qingzhu asked gently.

Liang Shi's brow furrowed tightly, her voice choking. "I didn't grope her⁵ while filming. I never liked her either. I didn't stick my tongue out during kissing scenes. In fact, all our scenes together were camera tricks⁶. I never had any inappropriate thoughts about her. At first, I might have had a tiny bit of favorable feelings."

"She was quite cute-looking. She would sweetly call me 'jiejie'⁷, give me little snacks and hand warmers. During night shoots, she would bring me steam eye masks." Liang Shi said, "So there was a tiny bit of favorable feelings, but I knew I couldn't. I couldn't like any girl, so I kept my distance from them."

"But I didn't know that after the drama finished airing, she would say that I..." Liang Shi paused, "Then everyone was cursing me, cursing me for being so disgusting, for riding on the drama's popularity to stir up a CP⁸, saying I was throwing myself at her. I saw all those words. They..."

Xu Qingzhu's fingers landed on her eyelashes, and she sighed softly.

Liang Shi stared at her very seriously.

Xu Qingzhu placed her hand on her back, slowly and gently patting it, then leaned forward to embrace her.

Her head buried in the crook of Liang Shi's shoulder, her lips landed on the skin of her neck, kissing it softly.

It was a restrained kiss, purely expressing heartache.

Liang Shi's body stiffened. Xu Qingzhu said in a low voice, "Teacher Liang, I'm too cold. Can you hold me tighter?"

A moment later, Liang Shi draped her own coat over her, then threaded her arms through the narrow gap inside the coat and held her tight as she had asked.

The sea breeze blew from the distant ocean surface, stirring up waves in the sea, yet it only gently brushed over their bodies.

Under the black coat, they pressed tightly against each other, creating a new, tender little world.

Undisturbed by anyone.

After a while, Xu Qingzhu continued to ask, "What did they say about you?"

"They said I wasn't worthy of that person, that I wasn't qualified to win awards, and that my family members deserved to die... so early." By the end, Liang Shi's entire body was trembling.

Xu Qingzhu gently stroked her back, but her voice took on a crisp edge. "Was that person very good? Pretty? What was so good about her? Her intelligence or her looks?"

Liang Shi said, "They were all okay, I guess. Nothing particularly outstanding."

"Then how is our Teacher Liang not worthy?" Xu Qingzhu said firmly. "Our Teacher Liang is worthy of anyone. It's *her* who isn't worthy of our Teacher Liang."

Hearing this, Liang Shi chuckled softly, but only buried her head in Xu Qingzhu's neck, her lips lightly touching Xu Qingzhu's skin.

She asked in a low voice, "Zhuzi, I want to bite you. May I?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She didn't understand this strange quirk of Liang Shi's when she was drunk.

First, she had kissed the top of her foot, then brought her to see the ocean.

Now, wanting to bite her—compared to the previous two things, it seemed rather insignificant.

Especially in this kind of environment, in this kind of atmosphere...

Footnotes:

¹ **Gaokao (高考)**: The National College Entrance Examination in China, a highly competitive standardized test that determines university admissions. It is one of the most important events in a Chinese student's life.

² **"Didn't deserve her position" (德不配位)**: A Chinese idiom meaning one's virtue or ability doesn't match their position or status—essentially feeling like an imposter who doesn't deserve what they have achieved.

³ **"Toad wanting to eat swan meat" (癞蛤蟆想吃天鹅肉)**: A Chinese idiom describing someone of low status having unrealistic romantic aspirations toward someone far above them—similar to "punching above one's weight" but more derogatory.

⁴ **"Threw dirty water" (潑髒水)**: A Chinese expression meaning to slander or spread false accusations about someone.

⁵ **"Grove her" (鹹豬手)**: Literally "salty pig hands," this is a Chinese slang term for inappropriate touching or groping, typically referring to sexual harassment.

⁶ **"Camera tricks" (借位)**: A filming technique where actors appear to kiss or have physical contact but are actually positioned to create an illusion for the camera without actually touching. Common in the entertainment industry to avoid real intimate contact.

⁷ **Jiejie (姐姐)**: Meaning "older sister" in Chinese, but commonly used as an affectionate or respectful way to address an older female, even if not related.

⁸ **CP**: Short for "coupling" or "couple pairing," referring to fan-created romantic pairings of actors or characters. "Stirring up a CP" means deliberately creating romantic buzz between two people for publicity purposes.